ZIHAO LI

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EDUCATION

- **Lanzhou University** *Sep. 2023 - Present*
  B.A. in Journalism Lanzhou
  - **Relevant Coursework:** Journalism Theory (99), New Media User Analysis (95), Media Criticism (95), Research Methods in Communication Studies (95), Data Journalism (95), Introduction to Communication (95), Public Opinion (94), Communication Psychology (91)
  - **GPA:** 4.07/5
- **National Taiwan Normal University** *Aug. 2025 - Dec. 2025*
  Exchange Student Taipei
  - **Relevant Coursework:** New Media and Society Seminar (A), Research Method of Social Science (A), Visual Culture and Communication (A-)
  - **GPA:** 3.9/4.0

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS & CONFERENCE PAPERS

Should I Stay Calm: How Does the Combination of Visual and Textual Frames Influence Expressions of Anger in Short Video Comment Sections?

Zihao Li.* *AEJMC 2026* [🌐]

- Developed an AI-agent-based approach to analyze visual and textual affective frames in short videos, using machine learning to measure anger expressed in audience comments and examine how different multimodal frame combinations relate to anger during public controversies in China.
- Found that visual and textual frames tended to align and were independently associated with audience anger. A two-way ANOVA showed significant main effects for both modalities but no significant interaction.

Generation, Negotiation, and Connection: Participatory Curation and Platformized Production of Urban Digital Memory on Short-Video Platforms

M. Xiao, R. Zhao, & Zihao Li.* *Chinese Platform Studies Academic Workshop 2026*

- Conducted computational analysis for a study of urban digital memory on Douyin. Collected and preprocessed video and comment data, developed a customized local place-name dictionary, and applied BERTopic, NMF, and topic similarity analysis to identify recurring discourse topics and examine semantic relationships.
- Drawing on Hoskins' connective memory theory, the study shows how participatory interactions transform personal memories into shared urban narratives, while visual content connects users across generations and regions.

WORKING PAPERS

Moral Cues in Visual Misinformation: Visual Event Schemas and the Moral Reorientation of Authentic Images

Xinxin Li, & Zihao Li.* *Manuscript in Preparation* [🌐]

- Combined Moral Foundations Theory with visual event schemas to examine how false captions reconstruct the moral meanings of authentic images in cheap fakes, providing a framework for understanding image–text interactions in multimodal misinformation.
- Contributed to research design, data collection, analysis, and manuscript writing. Paired false claims with the original contexts of corresponding images, extracted variables using computer vision, and conducted latent class analysis and linear regression.

From Emotion to Hostility: Discrete Negative Emotions and Gender-Directed Incivility in Chinese Gender-Issue Short Videos

Zihao Li.* *Under Review, ICA 2027* [🌐]

- Designed and conducted a computational study of gender-related discussions on Chinese TikTok. Used a multimodal emotion model to measure discrete emotions in videos and developed a supervised classifier to identify incivility and gender-directed hostility in comments. Applied binomial regression and interaction tests to examine emotion–incivility associations.
- Found that anger was positively associated with incivility, while fear showed a negative association. These associations varied with video content context and the targets of hostile comments.

See It, Click It? How Visual Clickbait Shapes Stratified User Engagement in Health-Related Videos on China's Bilibili

Zihao Li.* *Under Review, ICA 2027* [🌐]

- Examined visual clickbait in health-related Bilibili videos using computational methods. Collected thumbnails and engagement data, using LLM-assisted coding and Chinese-CLIP to measure visual cues and thumbnail–title congruence. Applied negative binomial regression to examine engagement outcomes.
- Found that binary clickbait measures may obscure differences among visual strategies. Clickbait was positively associated with views; after adjusting for view counts, it was negatively associated with likes, coins, favorites, and shares, highlighting differences between attention and deeper engagement.

Research Experience

A Study on Discourse Construction and Visual Narrative Strategies in the New Mainstream Media Environment of the Converged Media Era

Research Assistant | PI: Xinxin Li, Lanzhou University *Dec. 2024 - Apr. 2025* [🌐]

- Built a dataset of People's Daily environmental reporting from 1949 to the present and developed an LLM-based automated coding pipeline. Using Fairclough's discourse analysis framework and the history of China's environmental policies, identified distinct phases of environmental discourse and developed the findings into a research paper.
- Developed a web crawler to collect environmental posts published by People's Daily on Weibo and compared them with its print editions to examine differences in environmental reporting across platforms.

A Study on the "Human-Machine Co-creation" Mechanism and Innovative Practices in AI-Empowered Cultural Narratives Along the Silk Road

Research Assistant | PI: Xinxin Li, Lanzhou University *Mar. 2025 - May. 2025*

- Compiled and organized narrative materials on the historical development of the Silk Road.
- Synthesized research trends in Silk Road studies across multiple social science disciplines and developed them into a comprehensive literature review.

Lanzhou Bathing Assistant: Seeing Aging at Mobile Bathhouses

Field Research | Advisor: Shiping, Lanzhou University *Aug. 2024 - Jan. 2025* [🌐]

- Conducted ethnographic fieldwork on Lanzhou's emerging in-home elder-bathing industry, examining bodily dignity and social invisibility among disabled and bedridden older adults under China's home-based eldercare model.
- Combined participant observation with semi-structured interviews involving the company founder, bathing assistants, eldercare-center managers, and family caregivers. Analyzed how demographic change, local climate, economic conditions, bathing culture, and attitudes toward aging shaped the industrys development in northwest China. Produced an in-depth research report and short video documentary.

Why Do College Students Have a Particular Affinity for Life "Within the System"?

Student Research | Advisor: Zhangchi, Lanzhou University *Apr. 2024 - Apr. 2025*

- Investigated Chinese college students' growing preference for public-sector employment through survey research. Contributed to questionnaire design, data collection, and statistical analysis to identify key predictors of career choices.
- Conducted semi-structured interviews to complement survey findings, exploring the motivations behind young Chinese people's preference for civil-service positions and developing evidence-based policy recommendations.

Selected Awards and Honors

- **China Data Journalism Competition**, *Second Prize* [🌐] *Nov. 2025*
- **China Statistical Modeling Competition, Lanzhou University Campus Round**, *Second Prize* [🌐] *May. 2026*
- **Central China Mathematical Modeling Competition**, *Second Prize* [🌐] *May. 2026*
- **China University Campus Media Competition**, *Public Service Communication Award* [🌐] *Nov. 2025*
- **14th China Tower Journalists' Day**, *Grand Prize in the Communications Category* [🌐] *Dec. 2025*

- **Lanzhou University Outstanding Student Scholarship** [🌐] *Sep. 2023 - Sep. 2024*

SKILLS

- **Programming:** R, Python, web development (HTML, CSS), AI4SS
- **Quantitative Methods:** Fundamentals of probability and statistics, regression, ANOVA
- **Computational Methods:** Natural language processing, automated content analysis, topic modeling, machine learning, image-as-data
- **Qualitative Methods:** Interviews, coding, content analysis, field research
- **Languages:** Mandarin (Native), English (TOEFL iBT: 5.0/6.0 (equivalent to 100/120; CEFR C1))
- **Production Tools:** LaTeX, Microsoft Office Suite, photography